



Inside the shadow economy behind cricket's biggest spectacle

Uncovering a **sprawling ecosystem** of fake ticketing portals, malware campaigns, betting networks, and money mule operations feeding off the IPL fever.

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Sunita Murthy, a security guard with a private agency, was assigned duty at the M. Chinnaswamy Stadium in Bengaluru on March 28.

With the Indian Premier League (IPL) fever sweeping the nation, Sunita understandably also didn't want to miss the opportunity to watch the action up close. So, when one of the bouncers mentioned he knew someone selling tickets, she promptly took down his contact details.

Her call went unanswered, but she got a reply on WhatsApp asking for an electronic transfer of ₹3,000 for two tickets. Minutes later, two QR code-bearing PDFs bearing her name landed in her mail.

There was little to suggest

anything unusual was taking place. Hence, over the next five days, Sunita made multiple purchases from the same worth ₹52,500.

By the time she realised the tickets were fake, the damage had already been done.

Sunita's experience was far from an isolated incident. In fact, cybersecurity firm CloudSEK believes she may be just one among "millions of IPL fans" who were exposed to similar scams this season.

Independent research identified more than 600 fraudulent domains selling fake tickets, over 400 illegal streaming websites, and another 1,200-plus domains promoting betting platforms where users allegedly faced difficulties while withdrawing their funds.

Counterfeit entry passes

"We have our proprietary product that helps do the digital risk monitoring. We had added a few watchwords like betting, IPL, fake tickets, and so on. That helped us scour through all of those domains or squatted domains that are actually impersonating legitimate businesses. So, the moment you add those keywords, the product goes around the Internet — be it on the deep web, dark web or surface web — to find out every mention of similar words," reveals Sourajeet Majumder, a security researcher at CloudSEK, specialising in cyber threat intelligence and offensive security.

That is when Sourajeet discovered multiple websites and applications masquerading as legitimate ticketing